Seventy years ago, as the Zionist leaders were preparing to declare independence, Hannah Arendt mused about the sort of country they would create. Arendt was born in Germany, but left in the 1930s, as the Nazis were first consolidating power. She is remembered today for her writings on fascism and for “Eichmann in Jerusalem”, her coverage of the Nazi leader’s 1961 trial, which coined the phrase “the banality of evil”. But she also wrote about Israel and Zionism, often critically. On 1 May 1948, just two weeks before Israel declared independence, she published a scathing essay in *Commentary*, then the most prominent journal of the Jewish intellectual left. (Today it takes a belligerent right-wing line on Israel; it marked the fiftieth anniversary of Eichmann in Jerusalem with a piece entitled “The Lies of Hannah Arendt”.)

Arendt predicted that a small Jewish state, surrounded by hostile Arab neighbors, would inevitably become warlike, “absorbed with physical self-defense”—unrecognizable to her American Jewish readers: “Under such circumstances… the Palestinian Jews would degenerate into one of those small warrior tribes about whose possibilities and importance history has amply informed us since the days of Sparta. Their relations with world Jewry would become problematical, since their defense interests might clash at any moment with those of other countries where large numbers of Jews lived. Palestine Jewry would eventually separate itself from the larger body of world Jewry and in its isolation develop into an entirely new people. Thus it becomes plain that at this moment and under present circumstances a Jewish state can only be erected at the price of the Jewish homeland.”[5]

The title of this book is a question: How long will Israel survive? I have no definitive answer. Nobody does. But the status quo is unsustainable. In a few decades, one-third of Israelis will be *haredim*, a group that mostly lives in poverty and contributes little to the national economy. More than half the country will not serve in the army, that longtime melting pot. Similarly, if trends continue, a solid majority of Israeli Jews will view Judaism as more important than democracy. Racism and nationalism are increasing, despite the tremendous improvement in Israel’s physical security. And the long-serving prime minister, instead of trying to address these long-term concerns, is busy trying to quash the few remaining bastions of dissent.

This, most of all, is the tragedy of the Netanyahu era. While the West is having similar arguments about identity and democracy, the choices are